

THE DOMINION LAND SURVEY

Surveying the Canadian Prairies 1871–1930

History, Structure & Local Legacy

[MAP PLACEHOLDER] Regional Overview Map — Townships 32–40, Ranges 1–5, W5
(Insert Map 1 here once generated)



*Research compiled 2025 · Sources: Library and Archives Canada, Statistics Canada, Alberta Parks,
Provincial Archives of Alberta, Natural Resources Canada, Red Deer County*

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1. Historical Background & Legislative Context

The Dominion Land Survey emerged directly from the nation-building imperatives of post-Confederation Canada. In 1870, the Dominion acquired Rupert's Land and the North-Western Territory from the Hudson's Bay Company, and the federal government required a mechanism to convert a vast fur-trade domain into legible, saleable, and governable property. That meant surveying land, reserving space for Indigenous reserves where treaties applied, financing railways, and attracting settlers with homestead grants. The DLS was therefore not merely a technical exercise; it was a sovereignty project and a colonization project simultaneously.

The survey project was adopted in 1871, and the first DLS stake was placed in Manitoba on 10 July 1871. The Dominion Lands Act received royal assent on 14 April 1872, supplying the legal framework for homesteads, survey rules, railway lands, and reserved lands. The statute made homesteading the core settlement device: a settler could enter a quarter-section of 160 acres for a \$10 filing fee, then receive patent after meeting residence and cultivation requirements. The original five-year residence requirement was later reduced to three years; the minimum age dropped from 21 to 18 in 1875; and women heads of families were admitted as entrants after 1876.

The most important technical figure in the system's creation was Lt.-Col. J.S. Dennis, the first Surveyor General of Dominion Lands. Administration shifted to the new Department of the Interior after 1873, and the dominion lands machinery was carried forward by officers such as Aquila Walsh.

The DLS was explicitly modelled on a modified U.S. Public Land Survey System, sharing principal meridians, baselines, six-mile townships, thirty-six one-mile sections, and periodic correction lines. The Canadian system was adapted, however, by building in road allowances and by reserving land for schools, the Hudson's Bay Company, railways, and Indigenous reserves — all reflecting specific Canadian political obligations.

When Canadian surveyors entered Red River in 1869–70, Métis residents resisted, helping trigger the Red River Resistance. This was not incidental — the square survey directly threatened the long-lot land-tenure system that Métis communities had developed along the rivers of the region.

2. Survey Geometry

Principal Meridians & Baselines

The DLS is organized around six principal north-south meridians and the Baseline at the 49th parallel (the Canada-U.S. border). Townships are numbered north from the Baseline; ranges are numbered east or west of each meridian.

Meridian	Longitude	Primary Region
Principal (1st)	97°27' W	Southern Manitoba
Second	102°00' W	Western Manitoba / East Saskatchewan
Third	106°00' W	Central Saskatchewan
Fourth	110°00' W	Alberta–Saskatchewan boundary
Fifth	114°00' W	Central Alberta (study area)
Sixth	118°00' W	Western Alberta / NE British Columbia

Table 1 — The six Principal Meridians of the DLS.

Township, Section & Quarter-Section Structure

Each township is a six-mile square containing 36 sections, each one square mile (640 acres). Sections are numbered 1–36 in a boustrophedon (snake) pattern: Section 1 begins in the southeast corner, numbering proceeds westward along the first tier, then eastward along the second, and so on until Section 36 reaches the northeast corner. Each section is divided into four quarter-sections of 160 acres (NW, NE, SW, SE) — the classic homestead allotment.

A full DLS legal description is written as: **NW-14-23-4-W5** — the northwest quarter of section 14, township 23, range 4, west of the 5th Meridian. This convention is still used in Alberta Land Titles, oil and gas leases, and municipal addressing today.

Legal Subdivision (LSD)

Each section can be further divided into 16 Legal Subdivisions (LSDs), each approximately 40 acres (roughly 402 × 402 metres). An LSD is one-sixteenth of a *section*, not a quarter — a common point of confusion. LSDs are used primarily in the oil and gas industry for well and facility location descriptions.

Road Allowances

Road allowances of one chain (66 feet) were built into the DLS grid from the outset, running along the south and west boundaries of each section. This modification from the U.S. model is why the prairie landscape presents such a striking mile-grid of rural roads and field boundaries, and why Alberta's range roads and township roads correspond so precisely to section lines.

3. Correction Lines

Because meridians converge on a spherical earth, a perfectly rectangular northward-running grid will narrow as it progresses north. The DLS solved this by inserting correction lines every 24 miles — that is, every four townships. At these lines, the range lines are readjusted westward to compensate for convergence, creating the characteristic 'jog' in roads and property lines that prairie residents notice where a road suddenly fails to align straight across a township boundary.

In the study area, correction lines fall at the boundaries of Townships 28, 32, 36, and 40. The T36/T37 boundary is therefore a correction line at the northern edge of the local Cottonwood/Gleniffer township block. The resulting road offsets are a routine and familiar feature of the central Alberta grid, visible across Red Deer County in satellite imagery and GIS layers.

4. Reserved & Special-Use Lands

School Sections (11 & 29)

Sections 11 and 29 in every township were retained as school lands. Revenue from their eventual sale was directed to provincial or territorial educational authorities. By 1913, the total acreage of school lands surveyed across the three prairie provinces reached 8,585,227 acres — equivalent to roughly 13,414 sections or 373 full townships devoted exclusively to education funding.

Hudson's Bay Company Sections

Under the 1870 Rupert's Land transfer agreement, the HBC was entitled to one-twentieth of the 'fertile belt.' In township practice this was implemented as section 8 and three-quarters of section 26 in each township, with the full section 26 reserved in every fifth township. These holdings created a further layer of interlocked ownership across the prairie checkerboard.

Railway Land Grants — CPR & Calgary and Edmonton Railway

The Canadian Pacific Railway received approximately 25 million acres under its 1881 charter, allocated as alternating odd-numbered sections within a belt extending 24 miles on either side of its main line. This created the famous railway 'checkerboard' of alternating railway and non-railway ownership, which shaped land values, settlement patterns, and town placement across the prairies.

For the Bowden–Innisfail corridor and the Cottonwood/Gleniffer study area, the relevant railway grant was not the CPR transcontinental main-line grant but the separate **Calgary and Edmonton Railway (C&E) grant**. Statistics Canada's 1903 railway land-grant table lists the C&E separately at 294.07 subsidized miles at 6,400 acres per mile — a total of 1,888,448 acres. Bowden originated as Siding 7 on the Calgary and Edmonton Railway in 1891, confirming that the C&E corridor ran directly through the study area.

A subsidy of 6,400 acres per mile implies a checkerboard reserve approximately 20 miles wide in total — considerably narrower than the CPR transcontinental belt. Whether the grant extended as far west as Ranges 2–3 W5 requires confirmation from a primary C&E land grant map or Western Land Grants liber (see Section 10, Open Questions).

First Nations Reserves

By 1913, 2,722,691 acres had been reserved for First Nations in the prairie provinces under treaty obligations, of which 576,781 acres had subsequently been surrendered. Métis claims were addressed partly outside the ordinary homestead framework through scrip, a process that often dispossessed rather than secured Métis land interests (see Section 7).

5. Statistical Profile

Total Survey Coverage

Total acreage surveyed (Manitoba, Saskatchewan, Alberta) by 1 Jan 1920	199,757,264 acres (~200 million)
Acreage alienated from Crown by 1920	120,894,407 acres (5,247 townships / 188,897 sq mi)
Acreage still available for homestead entry in 1920	24,952,300 acres
Total homestead opportunities created by the grid	More than 1,250,000 surveyed quarter-sections
School lands surveyed by 1913	8,585,227 acres
CPR main-line land grant	~25,000,000 acres
Calgary & Edmonton Railway grant	1,888,448 acres (294.07 miles × 6,400 ac/mi)
First Nations reserves surveyed by 1913	2,722,691 acres

Table 2 — Key DLS coverage statistics.

Homestead Entries 1874–1930 (National Annual Series)

The following table is transcribed from the 1931 Canada Year Book, which provides the official annual homestead entry series from 1874 to 1930. Reporting years changed over time: departmental years ended Oct. 31 (1874–1894), Dec. 31 (1895–1899), June 30 (1900–1906), and Mar. 31 thereafter. Federal control of Crown lands in the prairie provinces ended Oct. 1, 1930.

Decade	Total Entries	Notes
1874–1879	8,923	Early settlement, Manitoba focus
1880s	35,748	Post-CPR opening, first boom
1890s	36,766	Slower period, pre-Sifton
1900s	251,522	Great immigration boom — peak decade
1910s	255,589	Continued boom, WWI slowdown
1920s	66,144	Sharp post-war contraction
1930	17,504	Partial year to Oct. 1, 1930

Table 3 — Homestead entries by decade, 1874–1930.

Annual Entries — Full Series

Year	Entries	Year	Entries
1874	1,376	1902	14,633

Year	Entries	Year	Entries
1875	499	1903	31,383
1876	347	1904	26,073
1877	845	1905	30,819
1878	1,788	1906	41,869
1879	4,068	1907	21,647
1880	2,074	1908	30,424
1881	2,753	1909	39,081
1882	7,483	1910	41,568
1883	6,063	1911	44,479
1884	3,753	1912	39,151
1885	1,858	1913	33,699
1886	2,657	1914	31,829
1887	2,036	1915	24,088
1888	2,655	1916	17,030
1889	4,416	1917	11,199
1890	2,955	1918	8,319
1891	3,523	1919	4,227
1892	4,840	1920	6,732
1893	4,067	1921	5,389
1894	3,209	1922	7,349
1895	2,394	1923	5,343
1896	1,857	1924	3,843
1897	2,384	1925	3,653
1898	4,848	1926	4,685
1899	6,689	1927	5,760
1900	7,426	1928	7,233
1901	8,167	1929	16,157

Table 4 — Full annual homestead entry series 1874–1930 (source: *Canada Year Book*, 1931).

Provincial Homestead Split 1922–1931

The 1931 *Canada Year Book* provides a province-by-province breakdown from 1922. Alberta dominated entries in the final years of federal control, accounting for nearly 60% of prairie entries by 1929–30.

Fiscal Year (ended Mar 31)	Manitoba	Saskatchewan	Alberta	Prairie Total
1922	1,488	2,733	2,928	7,149
1923	879	2,104	2,207	5,190

Fiscal Year (ended Mar 31)	Manitoba	Saskatchewan	Alberta	Prairie Total
1924	632	1,699	1,347	3,678
1925	464	1,804	1,192	3,460
1926	616	2,363	1,556	4,535
1927	797	2,702	2,145	5,644
1928	688	2,961	3,411	7,060
1929	643	5,808	8,933	15,384
1930	727	6,089	9,795	16,611
1931*	454	2,834	7,122	10,410

Table 5 — Provincial homestead entries 1922–1931. *1931 is partial year to Oct. 1, 1930 only, when federal control of prairie Crown lands transferred to the provinces.

School Land Revenue

A single consolidated tri-provincial school land revenue total has not been located in a single official source, but confirmed figures for each province are as follows:

Province	Key Figure	Source / Notes
Manitoba	\$6,243,351 paid to province by 1927–28; ~\$300,000/year average over prior 5 years	1928 Royal Commission
Alberta	~3.77M acres set apart; ~1.57M acres sold; >\$20M actual cash paid (current + capital)	1935 Royal Commission
Saskatchewan	2,109,777 net acres sold; >\$33M net (after cancellations); >\$34M actual cash paid	1935 Royal Commission
Combined minimum	>\$60.9M in confirmed cash payments across three provinces	Derived — not apples-to-apples; see note

Table 6 — School land revenue by province. Figures are not directly comparable across provinces due to different reporting bases in the Royal Commission sources.

6. Local Focus — Cottonwood & West Innisfail

Township Geography

The study area straddles two meridian systems. Innisfail proper sits at 21-35-28-W4 (Township 35, Range 28, West of the 4th Meridian). Immediately west, the Cottonwood and Gleniffer district crosses into the 5th Meridian system. Alberta Parks' legal plan for Gleniffer Reservoir places the Cottonwood/Gleniffer lands in **Townships 35 and 36, Ranges 2 and 3, West of the 5th Meridian**.

The present road network in this district is a direct expression of the DLS grid. Alberta Parks' Gleniffer map labels Township Roads 352, 354, 355, and 360, together with Range Roads 23A, 24, 25, 30, 31, and 32 — precisely the mile-grid one expects from a settled prairie district whose road allowances were inherited from the 1871 survey and later municipalized by Red Deer County.

[MAP PLACEHOLDER] Local Detail Map — Townships 35–36, Ranges 2–3, W5 Showing sections, school sections (11 & 29), HBC sections, correction line at T36/T37 boundary
(Insert Map 2 here once generated)

Calgary & Edmonton Railway Lands

The railway land grant relevant to this district was the **Calgary and Edmonton Railway (C&E) grant**, not the CPR transcontinental main-line grant. The C&E ran north-south through the Bowden–Red Deer–Lacombe corridor; Bowden itself originated as Siding 7 on the C&E in 1891. The C&E received 6,400 acres per subsidized mile (1,888,448 acres total), implying a checkerboard reserve approximately 20 miles wide on either side of the right-of-way.

Whether the C&E checkerboard extended as far west as Ranges 2–3 W5 remains to be confirmed from a primary C&E land grant map or Land Grants liber. Range 2 W5 is the more plausible candidate than Range 3 W5 given

the corridor geometry, but this should be treated as an inference pending primary-source verification.

School Sections in the Local Townships

Sections 11 and 29 were school sections in every DLS township, including those in the Cottonwood/Gleniffer district. By 2009, parts of these sections had been assembled into the **Gleniffer Reservoir Provincial Recreation Area**:

- SE and NW quarters of Section 29, Township 35, Range 2, W5
- NE quarter of Section 11, Township 35, Range 3, W5

Alberta Parks' 2009 establishment order references Land Titles Plan 082 0268 in its saving-and-excepting clause, confirming these parcels were already outside ordinary private circulation by that date. The original school-land sale instruments can be traced through SPIN2 or a registry agent using historical title searches by legal description.

Named Settlers of the Cottonwood District

Research across postal history, place-name records, and local history sources has identified several confirmed early settlers tied to the target townships:

Name	Connection	Date / Details
William Robertson	Postmaster, Gleniffer post office (1913–1918)	Homesteaded c.1902; emigrated from Paisley, Scotland with wife and 7 children. Gleniffer Lake takes its name from his post office.
James Alexander Laird	Homesteader, Moose Ridge / Mountain House (6-35-3-W5)	Homesteaded 1903. Post office later moved to the Laird homestead; H.W. Grundy renamed it Moose Ridge in 1925.
Augustus Caldwell	First postmaster, Mountain House post office	Post office opened 1905-12-15.

Table 7 — Confirmed named settlers in the Cottonwood/Gleniffer district.

The Danish Settlement at Dickson

One of the most distinctive settlement stories in the broader west Innisfail area is the Danish community at **Dickson**, approximately 22 miles west of Innisfail. In 1903, **Carl Christiansen** and 17 Danish compatriots — many emigrating from Nebraska — settled a tract of land set aside specifically for their community. Henry and Jens Larsen made the reconnaissance trip to Alberta; a Henry Larsen Homestead Receipt dated 1903 survives in archival collections.

The 1903 pioneer cohort included **Fred Pedersen, John Jensen, and Laus Christensen**. The 1904 cohort added **I.C. Tromberg, Anton Laursen, and Rev. J.C. Gundesen**. The Dickson community became one of the most cohesive ethnic settlement clusters in central Alberta, and the Dickson Store has been designated a Canadian historic site. These names are locally attested in published community histories but await confirmation against primary LAC homestead index records.

7. The Métis River Lot System

The Métis river-lot system both preceded and, at key moments, directly conflicted with the DLS square grid. At Red River and the Assiniboine, the long-lot system was already in place before the federal survey arrived — dating to 1813, with land divided into narrow strips extending back from the rivers. George Taylor's 1836–38 survey plans documented lots beginning at the river and running approximately two miles long and 400 metres wide.

This system was not simply a different geometry; it expressed a different social and environmental logic. Narrow river frontages gave every household water access and transport, while shared hay and timber privileges reinforced community land use. All of this was materially incompatible with the DLS framework of standardized, alienable rectangular parcels.

The conflict came to a head in 1869–70 when Canada sent surveyors into the Red River territory without consultation. Louis Riel and Métis forces turned the surveyors away, triggering the Red River Resistance. The square survey threatened not only existing parcel shapes but community authority and land-use customs. Farther west, federal officials had difficulty adjudicating Métis river-lot claims in places such as Batoche and St. Laurent because they lacked reliable maps and consistent policy.

The Dominion Lands Act did not initially include Métis within its framework; amendments came only in 1879, and even then the process operated through scrip in ways that frequently dispossessed Métis communities rather than securing collective land bases. The DLS did not simply overlay an empty landscape with an orderly grid — in Manitoba and in Saskatchewan river communities, it displaced older land orders whose boundaries and commons did not fit the square township ideal.

8. Modern Legacy & Research Tools

The DLS never really disappeared. In 1930, responsibility for most DLS lands passed to the prairie provinces, but the survey fabric continued as the basis of provincial cadastral systems. In Alberta, this continuation is the **Alberta Township System (ATS)**, which underpins land titles, oil and gas well locations, the Alberta Energy Regulator, the Alberta Geological Survey, and open-data GIS layers.

Alberta's legal-land tools still teach users to search by quarter-section or LSD, section, township, range, and meridian. The ATS open-data layers are published as GIS-ready shapefiles explicitly described as the provincial continuation of the DLS. At the urban fringe of Calgary, Edmonton, and Red Deer, section-line roads and quarter-section boundaries continue to define development parcels and municipal road systems.

Key Research Tools

- **Alberta SPIN2** (Spatial and Property Information Network) — Public access to current and historical land titles by legal description; purchase historical title searches for cancelled instruments

- **Library and Archives Canada — Homestead Records** — Searchable database of homestead entries by township, range, and meridian; includes claimant names, entry dates, and patent information
- **LAC — Township Plans of the Canadian West** — Digitized original township survey plans; field notes and surveyors' diaries
- **LAC — Land Grants of Western Canada Libers** — Primary records of railway and other special land grants by legal description
- **Provincial Archives of Alberta** — Township Plans, Registers, and Settlement Maps series — confirmed holdings for T35-37, R2-3, W5
- **Alberta Open Data — ATS Shapefiles** — GIS-ready township grid for mapping and spatial analysis
- **Red Deer County Interactive Map** — Current land ownership and road network for the Cottonwood/Gleniffer district
- **Glenbow Archives** — CPR and C&E Railway land department records and historical maps

9. Maps & Visual Resources

The following maps have been commissioned to accompany this report. They will be inserted below once the GIS-generated files are received. All maps are derived from Alberta Township System open-data shapefiles, OpenStreetMap road data, and Natural Resources Canada hydrological layers.

[MAP PLACEHOLDER] Map 1 — Regional Overview Townships 32–40, Ranges 1–5, W5 | Scale: County level Shows: DLS township/range grid, study area highlight (T35–36 R2–3 W5), correction lines at T28/32/36/40 boundaries, towns of Innisfail/Bowden/Red Deer, Red Deer River and Gleniffer Reservoir

[MAP PLACEHOLDER] Map 2 — Local Detail (Township Scale) Townships 35–36, Ranges 2–3, W5 | Scale: Section level Shows: Full 36-section grid with section numbers, school sections 11 & 29 highlighted, HBC sections 8 & 26 highlighted, C&E; Railway checkerboard (pending confirmation), correction line jog at T36/T37, Range Roads and Township Roads labeled, Gleniffer Reservoir

[MAP PLACEHOLDER] Map 3 — Homestead Entry Distribution T35–36, R2–3, W5 | Scale: Section level, colour-coded by decade Shows: Homestead entry locations by decade (1880s–1920s). Requires LAC homestead index data — pending

[MAP PLACEHOLDER] Map 4 — Prairie-Scale DLS Overview Manitoba, Saskatchewan, Alberta | Scale: National Shows: Six Principal Meridians labeled, Baseline (49th parallel), CPR main line, correction line intervals, full ~200M-acre survey extent, study area locator dot

Additional historical map sources to consult: Library and Archives Canada digitized township plans for T35-36 R2-3 W5; Natural Resources Canada's historical Manual of Instructions for the Survey of Dominion Lands; Alberta Parks' Gleniffer Reservoir legal plan (references Land Titles Plan 082 0268); and Red Deer County Division 4 land ownership maps.

10. Open Questions & Archival Next Steps

Three substantive questions remain open after three research passes. Each has a clearly defined archival route for resolution:

1. C&E; Railway Checkerboard — Section-by-Section List for T35–36, R2–3, W5

A primary C&E; land grant map, a Western Land Grants liber entry keyed to these legal descriptions, or a CPR/C&E; land sales catalogue entry is needed. Best sources: Glenbow Archives CPR land records; LAC Land Grants of Western Canada Libers. Range 2 W5 is the stronger candidate for inclusion in the grant belt; Range 3 W5 is less certain.

2. Named Homestead Entrants — Quarter-Section Roster with Entry & Patent Dates

The LAC Homestead Records database (searchable by township/range/meridian) and the Provincial Archives of Alberta Township Plans, Registers, and Settlement Maps series for T35-37 R2-3 W5 are the primary routes. Several settler names are confirmed from postal history and community records (Robertson, Laird, Caldwell, the Dickson Danish community), but the full legal-description roster with dates remains to be extracted.

3. School Section Sale History — Original Transfers for Sections 11 & 29

Alberta SPIN2 historical title searches by legal description, or a request to the Land Titles and Surveys office for older cancelled titles, will recover the original sale dates, purchaser names, and prices. It is confirmed that parts of these sections were incorporated into the Gleniffer Reservoir Provincial Recreation Area by 2009 (referencing Land Titles Plan 082 0268).

Note: The pre-1922 annual province-by-province homestead entry series (Manitoba/Saskatchewan/Alberta separately) was not recovered from a single official table in the research passes completed. This could be reconstructed from Department of the Interior annual reports held at LAC or the Internet Archive.

11. Sources & Further Reading

Primary Archival Sources

- Library and Archives Canada — Homestead Records database:
bac-lac.gc.ca/eng/discover/land/homestead-records
- Library and Archives Canada — Township Plans of the Canadian West (digitized original survey plans and field notes)
- Library and Archives Canada — Land Grants of Western Canada Libers
- Library and Archives Canada — Dominion Land Surveyors' diaries
- Provincial Archives of Alberta — Township Plans, Registers, and Settlement Maps series (confirmed for T35-37, R2-3, W5)

- Glenbow Archives — CPR and Calgary & Edmonton Railway land department records

Official Statistical Sources

- Canada Year Book 1931 — Annual homestead entry series 1874–1930
- Statistics Canada — 1920 public lands summary (199,757,264 acres surveyed)
- Statistics Canada — 1903 railway land-grant table (C&E;: 294.07 mi, 6,400 ac/mi)
- Department of the Interior Annual Reports (LAC / Internet Archive)
- 1928 Royal Commission — Manitoba School Lands Trust Fund
- 1935 Royal Commission — Alberta and Saskatchewan school lands revenue

Government Geospatial & Land Records

- Alberta SPIN2 (Spatial and Property Information Network) — spin2.alberta.ca
- Alberta Open Data — Alberta Township System (ATS) shapefiles
- Alberta Energy Regulator — ATS coordinate conversion tools
- Alberta Parks — Gleniffer Reservoir Provincial Recreation Area legal plan (Land Titles Plan 082 0268)
- Red Deer County — Division 4 land ownership and interactive maps
- Natural Resources Canada — GeoNames (place-name records: Innisfail, Bowden, Gleniffer)
- Natural Resources Canada — Historical Manual of Instructions for the Survey of Dominion Lands

Local & Community History

- Cottonwood-Gordon Agricultural Society — local hall and district records
- Alberta place-names record — Gleniffer (postmaster William Robertson, Paisley Scotland, homesteaded c.1902)
- Alberta place-names record — Moose Ridge / Mountain House (6-35-3-W5; James Alexander Laird, homesteaded 1903)
- Canadian Register — Dickson Store and Site (Carl Christiansen, 1903; 17 Danish settlers from Nebraska)
- Stories of Our People / Notre mémoire en ligne — Henry Larsen Homestead Receipt 1903 (Dickson Danish settlement)

Secondary Literature

- Manitoba Historical Society — Studies of prairie settlement patterns and HBC/railway/school-land interlocking checkerboard ownership
- University of Manitoba — Cultural-landscape history of the Métis river-lot system (dated to 1813 at Red River)
- Canada's History — Red River Resistance and the square survey conflict
- Esri GIS Dictionary — Definition of correction lines in the DLS/PLSS

